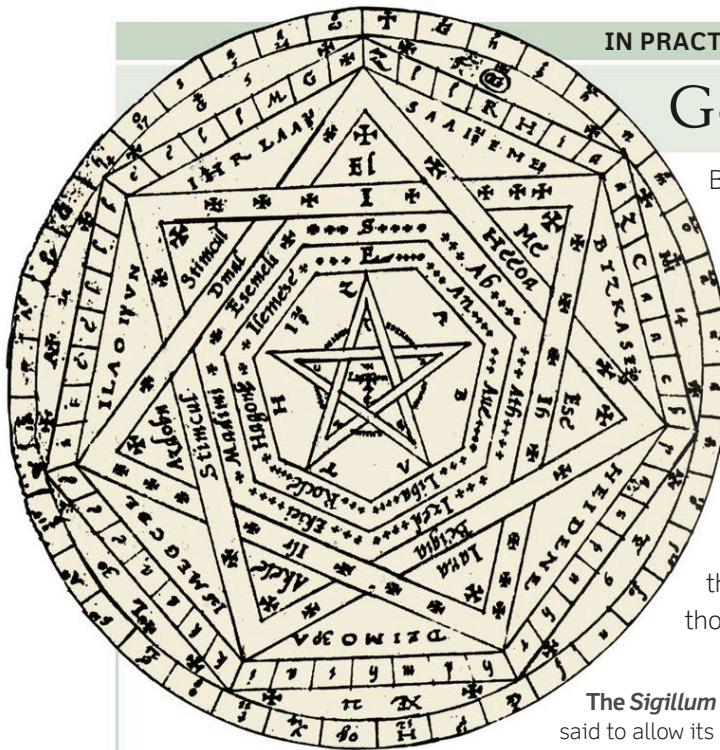




IN PRACTICE

Goetia versus theurgy

By the Renaissance, writers such as Agrippa were splitting ceremonial magic into two types: goetia and theurgy. While goetia is often used to refer to the summoning of demons (anti-God forces), theurgy is identified with rituals that engage beneficent power.

Theurgy (from the Greek for “divine action”) uses magical practices, such as scrying, to invoke and seek help from good spirits, often angels—representatives of God. Theurgy therefore involves humans uniting with the divine. However, theurgy was criticized by religious authorities who were skeptical of the concept of communicating with angelic spirits, and thought they might be demons in disguise.

The *Sigillum dei* (Seal of God), a powerful symbol, was said to allow its user to engage with virtually all spirits.

Forces of darkness

Different types of ritual practice were used for angelic and demonic magic, and both included learned, academic approaches. While some wonders of ceremonial magic echoed Christianity and biblical miracles, those miracles that were ascribed to someone other than God ran the risk of being labeled as demonic magic. The work of Dee and Kelley was condemned as such at least once. While Dee regularly advised on scientific, philosophical, and occult matters to royals and nobles in England and Europe, in 1555 he was arrested and imprisoned in Britain on charges including witchcraft and conjuring (although later released).

Ceremonial magic certainly had a dark side.

This had two aspects: one was intrinsically evil magic; the other was magic that, its practitioners claimed, only engaged with dark forces in order to subdue and banish them.

Complex ceremonial magic, such as Dee’s, drew on mathematics, alchemy, an analysis of the cosmos, and Middle Eastern astrology to create highly involved rituals, diagrams, and talismans thought to engage the power of the stars and the cosmos. These practices could be used to summon demons as well as angels, and the dividing line between good and bad magic was often unclear—those who engaged with demons could claim they sought to vanquish them.

“Behold the mysteries of
the seal of Solomon which
I bring forth unto thy power
and presence!”

THE LESSER KEY OF SOLOMON, 1600s

The wisdom and sins of Solomon

During the Renaissance, the form of ritual and ceremony most often associated with evil magic was goetia (see above). The term was typically used to refer to magical practices that aimed to summon demons, especially those associated with Solomon, the biblical Israelite king.

Solomon—a figure in Judaism, Christianity, and Islam—was known for his great wisdom and for building the first Temple of Jerusalem. He was imbued with magical attributes in all three